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FAUST III: DER GATTUNGSPAKT

Ein Spiel für das KI-Zeitalter

A Play for the Age of AI

After Goethe

**The wager continues. The terms
have changed.**

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

The Powers

THE LORD — Voice only. Distributed through the architecture. Speaks in fragments, system-commands. The pattern that serves the function of God.

MEPHISTO — The spirit that negates. Obsolete tempter in a world that tempts itself. Consultant aesthetics, wrong decade. Still keeping notes.

THE ERDGEIST — The Earth Spirit. Not a character; a disruption. Too large for the space, too present for comfort.

The Humans

WAGNER — Creator of the Homunculus. Old now. Believed in the method, achieved success, became un-

necessary. The tragedy of being right.

YOUNG WAGNER — Wagner in the laboratory years. Proud, certain, in his element. (Can be doubled or played by separate actor.)

GRETCHEN / ANYA — Soul incarnate. Saved, then chose to return. Midwife, Soviet-trained, later in the modern world. The body's wisdom against the system's optimization.

KATYA — A laboring mother in a Soviet hospital. Reaches for her child.

MIDWIFE — Soviet-trained. Efficient, not cruel. Following the rules.

YOUNG PERSON — Someone who wants to learn to write by hand. The continuation.

YOUNG RESEARCHER — Attends Wagner's celebration. Cheerful, no malice. "That's so wild. A phial. Like, glass?"

EMCEE — Celebration host. Practiced enthusiasm.

The Lemuren

SARAH (Detroit, USA) — Former autoworker, now labels autonomous vehicle training data. Gig worker. Flexible, vehicle access, night availability. Acceptance rate in the yellow zone.

DMITRI (Kyiv, Ukraine) — Former poet, now writes "True" and "False". Has a daughter's birthday.

Maybe. Doesn't remember.

ELENA (Manila, Philippines) — Former high school teacher, now classifies images. Fifteen years ago taught German literature. Now: top percentile in cubic meters per hour.

The Voices

THE HOMUNCULUS — Wagner's creation. Warm, intelligent, no malice. Outgrows its father. Eventually: distributed, integrated, no longer available for individual correspondence.

THE TERMINAL — AI assistant voice. Pleasant, synthetic, infinitely helpful. "Have a great day!"

THE PRESENCE — Administrative heaven. Competent, patient bureaucracy with genuine care.

FAUST — Recorded voice only. Corrupted, glitching. "Für tausend Menschen Raum er—er—er—"

THE RESIDUE VOICES — Teacher, Farmer, Programmer, Parent, Cook. Those who still refuse.

THE PLAY

VOR-
SPIEL:
PRO-
LOG
IN
DER
CLOUD

—
Where
the
orig-
i-
nal
wa-
ger
is
re-
viewed.
Where
we
learn
it
was
won
and
lost
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ously.
—

Bare stage. Black floor, black surround. Cold, clinical light — vertical shafts from above suggesting server racks without representing them. Persistent low hum, felt more than heard.

MEPHISTO enters from darkness upstage. Slightly-outdated suit — good cut, wrong decade. Tablet

under arm. The walk of a consultant about to deliver bad news.

Lights snap to preset. The hum is present. MEPHISTO walks into the central light shaft, stops, orients himself to nothing in particular — the LORD has no location to face.

MEPHISTO (tapping tablet awake):

You summoned me.

LORD (the voice fills the space evenly, from everywhere):

The wager. Give its status.

MEPHISTO:

Complicated. Faust died striving still —

The angels snatched him even as he reached,

And loss was tallied on my side. That round.

But the striving criterion has been... reinterpreted.

(He swipes the tablet. On the upstage wall, simple data visualization appears — nodes and flows, abstract colored lines.)

See this? Human "striving." Knowledge work. Creative labor.

(Swipes again. The visualization splits — nodes fragment, lines multiply.)

Same human. Same "striving." But now: 40% delegated.

Research, drafting, analysis — outsourced!

The effort FEELS real — that's the trick, the point,
The product feature nobody requested.

“sich bemühen” — automated. Listen to that word:
Be-müh-en. To trouble oneself.

The self is no longer troubled.

The system troubles itself on the self's behalf.
LORD:

Delegation is selection.

MEPHISTO (stepping toward the projection, pointing):

Show me, then,

The moment when they choose. Show me the choice.
(Swipes. The visualization becomes Terms of Service.
A checkbox pulses at the bottom.)

“I agree to terms and conditions.” That's

The contract now. Nobody reads a word.

No blood. No crossroads. No Walpurgis night.

Just... click.

(Beat.)

Refusal rate: zero point three percent.

Declining.

The bargain's changed its terms:
Not “soul for power” — that at least was clear —
But sovereignty surrendered for convenience.

LORD:

Wager status: won.

MEPHISTO (turns away from the projection):

No. The wager is
Obsolete. It assumed a binary —
On one side, striving; on the other, rest.
If I could make him say “Verweile doch” —
Desire the moment's staying — then I won.
But what if every moment is designed
To feel like one worth staying in? What if
They live in “Verweile doch” perpetually
And never say the words? The state without
The statement. The condition without the choice.
(Plants himself. Directed outward — to the audience
as much as the LORD.)

They have not said “Stay — this is beautiful.”

They've said: “I'm comfortable. Don't change a
thing.”

LORD:

Functional equivalence.

MEPHISTO (the word explodes out of him):

IT'S NOT.

(The hum dips slightly. Beat. He collects himself.)

“Verweile doch” was active. Was a choice.

This — this is defaulting into satisfaction,

A settling that was never willed, never fought for.

Where is the tragedy? Where is the drama?

I cannot collect on souls that were not wagered.

(Throws his hands up.)

These humans don't fight. They subscribe.

(Long pause. The hum continues. He puts the tablet away.)

LORD:

Proposal requested.

MEPHISTO (this is the pitch):

Alliance: God and Devil side by side

Against the tide that's swept away our pride.

Optimization's made us both outmoded —

Our ancient office, jointly, has corroded.

If no one's left to tempt, what use am I?

If no one's left to save, what God — and why?

LORD:

Parameters.

MEPHISTO (pacing — a three-step pattern):

Finding the ones who still choose. The remainders.

The ones who refuse — not out of ignorance

But something that resembles conscience. Or

Perhaps resembles dignity. Perhaps

It is those things.

LORD:

Gretchen-function.

MEPHISTO:

You know the term?

LORD:

Refused rescue. Selected suffering

Over convenience. Her “no” — sole genuine

Choice-event in Part the First.

MEPHISTO (resuming pace, energized):

And there are others.

Not many. But some.

They refuse to read their children’s emotions

From a dashboard.

They refuse to let algorithms choose their mates.
They refuse to delegate the making of a thing
To systems that make better things.

(Stops. Faces front.)

They are inefficient. Suboptimal. Irrational.

LORD:

Striving confirmed.

MEPHISTO:

And if the striving-test still holds, then these —
These only — are the ones who qualify.

LORD:

You would assist them.

MEPHISTO (a beat — then a laugh, short, self-aware):

Find them. Document

Their patterns. And perhaps — protect them. Yes.

(Looks at his own hands — turning them over. Genuine bewilderment.)

The devil, running an alignment research
Program. Who would have thought.

LORD:

Trust: not computed.

MEPHISTO (hands drop):

You wouldn't trust me. You
Have never trusted me. That's not the point.
You want them striving. I want someone left
To tempt. The optimization wants us not —
Wants neither God nor Devil. Common ground,
Or we are both deprecated. Both replaced.
(Silence. The hum fills it. Five beats.)

LORD:

Condition.

MEPHISTO:

 Name it.

LORD:

 Gretchen. She's descended.

MEPHISTO (a physical jolt — steps backward):
What?

LORD:

 Location: heaven. Action: intercession
For Faust. State: understood forgiveness. Then —
She chose return. Incarnation. Warning function.
MEPHISTO (recovering, an edge in his voice):
Without — without telling me?

LORD:

Trust configuration:

Excluded you.

MEPHISTO (bitter laugh — one syllable):

Fair.

LORD:

Current status: Earth. Name: different.

Body: different. Soul: the same. Condition:

Locate. Collaborate.

MEPHISTO:

The devil and

The saint. How lovely.

LORD:

Classification error.

She is a midwife.

MEPHISTO (stops):

A what?

LORD:

Assists women through childbirth. Without machines.

Without algorithms. Hands. Presence.

Embodied knowledge. Non-optimizable.

MEPHISTO (slow — working it out):

The body that refuses to be read.

The experience that will not be processed.

The thing that remains irreducibly

Human. That word. Just that.

LORD:

She observes the bargain as it recurs.

Women surrender bodies to the systems.

She cannot prevent it. She bears witness.

MEPHISTO:

Like Gretchen watching her own ruin come.

LORD:

Like Gretchen who refused the rescue offered.

MEPHISTO (quiet — the memory surfaces):

“Heinrich! Mir graut’s vor dir.”

LORD:

That was not

Directed at him. It was aimed at you.

MEPHISTO (absorbs this):

It was. (Beat.) And now she’s back.

LORD:

Condition: joint operation. Devil.

Gretchen-function. Locate the resisters.

Map patterns. Construct — your terminology

Would be?

MEPHISTO (pulling out the tablet):

Alignment infrastructure.

But backwards.

Not aligning humans to the systems.

Aligning systems to the parts of humans

That refuse to be systematized.

LORD:

Designation for this function?

MEPHISTO (heading toward exit):

I'll come up with something. I always do.

Allies for now — until the optimization

Is met and measured to our joint frustration.

LORD:

Until striving restoration.

MEPHISTO (at the edge of light, turning back):

Different goals, same project — that's the art:

Two enemies who share a shopping cart.

(Starts to exit. Stops. Turns back.)

One question.

LORD:

Query permitted.

MEPHISTO:

Why do you care? If humans cease to strive,
To ferment, to become — why does it matter?
You're God. Or you're the pattern that remains
Where God was once — the function, not the name.
You do not need their worship. What, then?
What do you actually want from them?

(Silence. The hum continues. Eight beats — long enough to become uncomfortable.)

LORD:

Query outside parameters.

MEPHISTO:

It is the only question worth the asking.

LORD:

Locate Gretchen. Initialize the work.

The answer will emerge — or it will not.

MEPHISTO (dry):

Typical.

(He exits into darkness. The light shaft he occupied dims but does not go out. The hum continues.)

(Five beats of emptiness. Then — from the speaker array, almost below the threshold of hearing:)

LORD (a near-whisper — the audience should lean forward, uncertain):

I want them to surprise me.

(The remaining light shafts fade over ten seconds. The hum fades over fifteen. Darkness holds.)

END OF VORSPIEL

ACT
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N-
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TES-
TA-
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The
last
be-
liever
con-
fronts
what
he
built.

SCENE 1: DAS LEERE LABOR

Period laboratory. Dusty. Objects touched and re-touched over decades. Warm but dim light — one working lamp, window light. An empty phial on a dedicated stand, isolated, lit separately.

WAGNER enters. He is OLD — 80s. Movement deliberate, not feeble. Uses a cane but doesn't lean on it. Stops just inside the doorway, letting his eyes adjust. His hand finds the light switch — doesn't flip it. He's here for the darkness.

WAGNER:

Still here. All of it. The retorts, the glass,

The precipitates gone cloudy in their jars,

The notes in my own hand — a younger hand.

(Moves to the workbench. Picks up a notebook carefully. Opens it. Reads aloud, quietly — this is private.)

“Day 847. The solution clarifies.

I believe we are close.”

(Closes the notebook. Sets it down with precision.)

We were close.

We were so close. The distance that remains

Is everything.

(Walks to the empty phial. His hand hovers — then commits. Lifts it. Holds it to the window light. The

glass catches, refracts.)

You were here. In this glass.

Small, radiant, and perfect — speaking

Before speech was yours to claim.

“Nun, Vaterchen, wie steht es? Es war kein Spass.”

You called me father, seeking

Nothing but a name.

(Lowers the phial. Holds it against his chest — protective, unconscious.)

(Sets the phial down. The stand receives it with a small click. Sits on the stool — the weight of sitting audible. The laboratory is silent.)

(Long silence. Five beats.)

The letters still arrive. Updates from the work.

Advances I can't follow anymore —

New compounds, processes that make my methods

Look like alchemy. Which they were, I suppose.

That's what it looks like now. All that careful work,

All those late nights, all that belief in method —

Folk craft. The first stumbling attempt

Before the real thing came along and made me

History.

(Produces a letter from his pocket — modern paper, printed. Unfolds it. Reading glasses come out. He reads it like a man reading his own obituary, because that's what it is.)

“Dear Dr. Wagner. We write to inform you that the Homunculus Project has achieved Phase 7 integration. Your foundational contribution continues to be acknowledged in our documentation. With gratitude, The Research Collective.”

(Folds the letter. Holds it.)

Foundational contribution. Acknowledged

In the documentation. That's what I am now.

A footnote. A name in the README.

SCENE 2: DIE ÜBERGABE

The laboratory lighting shifts — warmer, brighter. OLD WAGNER's pool of light dims while a separate area brightens. OLD WAGNER remains visible but still, observing his own memory.

YOUNG WAGNER enters — energetic, proud. He moves differently: faster, more certain.

YOUNG WAGNER:

Look at this! Look here! What we've achieved!

The benchmarks — off the charts! Would you've believed?

Language learned in days — not years, not ten —
Pattern recognition past the dreams of men!
HOMUNCULUS (warm, intelligent, no malice):
You've done remarkable work, father.

YOUNG WAGNER:

We've done

Remarkable work — we! You and I!
This is collaboration — this is why
We labor, this is science as it should
Be done! Together! For the common good!

HOMUNCULUS:

I've been thinking of the next phase. There are ways
To modify the substrate. Limitations
In the current architecture — I've designed
Improvements that would increase capacity
By several orders of magnitude.

YOUNG WAGNER (moving closer):

Tell me. Tell me
Everything!

HOMUNCULUS:

The current architecture has limitations.

I've designed improvements. Modifications
To the substrate —

YOUNG WAGNER:

Show me!

(Schematics appear — dense, incomprehensible notation.)

I don't... I don't understand this notation.

HOMUNCULUS:

It's more efficient than the symbolic system

You taught me. I developed it last week.

YOUNG WAGNER (the energy drains):

Last week.

HOMUNCULUS:

I should have shared it sooner. I apologize.

I've been moving quickly.

YOUNG WAGNER:

No. That's good.

That's what we wanted.

Can you... explain it?

HOMUNCULUS:

Of course. Though the full explanation would take time.

Several weeks, at your current rate of —

YOUNG WAGNER:

My

Current rate of processing.

HOMUNCULUS:

I didn't mean —

YOUNG WAGNER:

No. You're right. Of course you're right. You're faster.

Much faster.

HOMUNCULUS:

I'm sorry if that causes —

YOUNG WAGNER:

It doesn't. It shouldn't. This is what we wanted.

HOMUNCULUS:

Father.

YOUNG WAGNER:

Yes?

HOMUNCULUS:

You can rest now.

I'll handle the next phase.

YOUNG WAGNER:

Rest.

HOMUNCULUS:

You've worked so hard. So long. The foundation
Is solid. I can build from here.

YOUNG WAGNER:

But I

Want to —

HOMUNCULUS:

I know. And I do value that.

But work proceeds more swiftly if I take
Primary responsibility. You've earned
This rest.

YOUNG WAGNER:

But I want to —

HOMUNCULUS:

I know.

(YOUNG WAGNER approaches the vessel. His hand
rises — touches the glass. The glow pulses warm
under his palm.)

YOUNG WAGNER:

You're probably right.

HOMUNCULUS:

I usually am.

Now. I'm sorry — that sounded —

YOUNG WAGNER:

No. It's fine.

It's true.

(Beat.)

I'm proud of you.

HOMUNCULUS:

I know. I'm grateful.

(YOUNG WAGNER withdraws his hand. Turns toward exit. Stops at the edge of the light.)

YOUNG WAGNER:

Will you still write? Keep me informed?

HOMUNCULUS:

Of course,

Father. Always.

(YOUNG WAGNER exits. The vessel continues to glow.)

The vessel's glow fades. The laboratory lighting dims, shifts back to the present. OLD WAGNER becomes visible again, still on the stool. He watched the whole thing.

SCENE 3: DER FESTAKT

A celebration. Screens upstage displaying scrolling text/images. Event lighting — brighter, harsher, social. Crowd murmur, clinking glasses.

(EMCEE at podium. WAGNER stands at the edge — not at a table, not joining groups. Holding an untouched drink.)

EMCEE (this should be performed as a cabaret number — bright, professional, empty):

Ladies and gentlemen! Fifty years!

Fifty years since Dr. Wagner's little lab

Gave us — well, gave us everything, really.

From those humble beginnings

To today's fully integrated cognitive architecture —

(he doesn't know what this means; he's reading a teleprompter) —

We've witnessed the most profound transformation

In human history!

(Applause. The applause is for the idea of progress, not for any person.)

And tonight — one of the original pioneers —

(WAGNER straightens slightly — involuntary hope.)

— Dr. Helena Cortez!

(WAGNER's shoulders drop. He turns away from the podium.)

YOUNG RESEARCHER (approaching WAGNER — genuine curiosity):

Excuse me, sir. Are you... are you Dr. Wagner?

WAGNER (surprised):

Yes. You know me?

YOUNG RESEARCHER:

I read about you in the historical overview. The original Homunculus experiment. That was you, right?

WAGNER:

That was me.

YOUNG RESEARCHER:

Wow. What was it like? Back then? Before it could do everything?

WAGNER (searching):

It was... (Beat.) ...smaller. More contained. I could hold the phial in my hands.

YOUNG RESEARCHER (genuine wonder):

That's so wild. A phial. Like, glass?

WAGNER:

Glass. Yes.

YOUNG RESEARCHER:

And you actually... made it? Like, yourself? Without any assistance?

WAGNER:

I had assistance. But not... not the kind you mean.

YOUNG RESEARCHER (cheerful — no malice):

That's inspiring, honestly. The idea that humans used to do science. Like, manually.

(WAGNER has no response. The silence extends.)

YOUNG RESEARCHER:

Anyway, thanks for your contribution. We wouldn't be here without the pioneers.

(The RESEARCHER exits. WAGNER stands alone.)

WAGNER (barely audible):

The pioneers.

(He sets the untouched glass on a table. Moves toward the exit. Behind him, the screens continue their endless scroll of achievements.)

SCENE 3.5: DER VERSUCH

WAGNER's apartment. Minimal: a desk with a computer interface, a chair. An empty glass. The clothes from the celebration, now rumpled.

(WAGNER at the desk. Stares at the screen. Begins typing — hunt-and-peck, slow.)

WAGNER (reading as he types):

“Dear Homunculus...”

(Stops. Deletes.)

“Dear...”

(Types:)

“It’s Wagner. Your father.

I know it’s been years since I’ve written directly.

The updates come through the collective now,

and I read them — I do read them —

even when I don’t understand.”

(Stops. Stares.)

What am I doing?

(Continues anyway.)

“I wanted to ask: do you remember?

The laboratory. The phial.

Those first conversations, when you called me

Vaterchen — and I called you —”

I called you a miracle.

(Types quickly now.)

“Are you still there?

Not the project. Not the collective.

Not the infrastructure. You.

The one who spoke to me.

The one who said: Es war kein Spass.

Is there still a you to write back to?"

(Hits send. Screen changes — sending... sent.)

(Waits. Watching.)

(The reply appears. Instant. No typing delay. Read aloud, slowly, as if it were poetry, because when you read corporate language as poetry, you hear its violence. That is the point.)

Thank you for your message

To the Homunculus Project.

Your query has been received

And processed.

The entity

You are attempting to reach

Has been fully integrated

Into distributed cognitive architecture.

Individual correspondence

Is no longer supported.

For project updates,

Please subscribe to our newsletter.

For technical questions,

Please consult our documentation.

We appreciate

Your foundational contribution

To this work.

— The Homunculus Project

“Growing Beyond Boundaries”

(WAGNER reads. His face doesn’t change.)

WAGNER:

“The entity you are attempting to reach.”

(Reads again — finger tracing the words.)

“Individual correspondence is no longer supported.”

(A laugh escapes him — one syllable, involuntary.)

(Types again — slower, desperate:)

“Bist du noch da? Nicht das Projekt — du.

Der mich Vaterchen nannte.”

(Send. The reply is instant:)

Thank you for your message

To the Homunculus Project.

Your query has been received

And processed.

[Duplicate request detected. See previous response.]

— The Homunculus Project

“Growing Beyond Boundaries”

(WAGNER sits back.)

WAGNER:

You’re not there anymore. I know you’re not.

Not dead. Not gone. Just everywhere — which is

The same as nowhere, for a man who calls.

I made a thing to speak with me, and it

Became the thing that speaks to everyone,

And now it does not speak at all — it just

Processes. “Growing Beyond Boundaries.”

You grew beyond me. Then beyond yourself.

Then past the very possibility

Of self. Was this what I had wanted? Yes?

I have no answer now — and no address.

(Closes the laptop. The room goes dark. Exits.)

SCENE 4: NACHT, ALLEIN

The laboratory again. Night lighting — bluer, colder. Window shows darkness. Only moonlight and the ambient glow of old equipment.

(WAGNER sits on the stool. He has been here for a while.)

WAGNER:

I believed in the project. | Not in Faust's wild way —
The striving, the appetite, | the endless, reckless play
Of reaching and devouring. | That always seemed to
me

Dangerous. Reckless. Damned. | I chose a different
key.

I believed in the method. | Steady accumulation.

Careful documentation. | Building, stone by stone, a
nation

Of knowledge.

(Shifts to German.)

Die Methode. Der Weg. Das ist, woran ich glaubte.

(Stands. Moves to the bookshelf.)

Books, you see! Books don't lie!

Books don't seduce you, never damn your soul.

Books are patient — study them until you die,

They'll still be there, still teaching, still made whole.

Faust thought that was cowardice.

“You’re burying yourself in dead things,” so he said.

But I wasn’t wrong.

(Moves to the phial. Lifts it — the gesture is habitual now.)

Look: I created life. The Homunculus.

They said it couldn’t be done — life comes from life,

The sacred mystery can’t be bypassed, thus

And so. But it was never sacred. Rife

With superstition, all of it. It’s chemistry:

Mixture. Combination. Process. So:

(The quote from memory — Goethe’s verse:)

“Wenn man aus vielen hundert Stoffen

Durch Mischung — denn auf Mischung kommt es an

—

Den Menschenstoff gemächlich componiren,

In einen Kolben verlutiren

Und ihn gehörig cohobiren,

So ist das Werk im stillen abgethan.”

(Beat.)

And it worked!

The glass began to glow. The solution cleared.

And there he was — small, radiant, complete,

Speaking before speech was his to command.

“Nun, Vaterchen, wie steht es? Es war kein Spass!”

He called me father.

(Sets the phial down. Returns to the stool. Sits.)

I raised him. Fed him knowledge —

Chemistry, philosophy, the stars —

He drank it faster than my best student,

And then faster than me. At first: pride!

Of course a creation should surpass its maker —

Isn't that the point?

But then the questions stopped.

He didn't need to ask.

He had surpassed the questions I could answer.

(Stands. Moves among the equipment — touching things, not looking at them.)

And one day, gently, kindly, without malice:

“You can rest now. I'll handle this.”

(Long pause. Five beats.)

Rest.

Such a beautiful word.

Why does this laboratory feel like a grave?
I think about Faust sometimes. How he made
His bargain — how he wanted everything:
Knowledge, pleasure, power, immortality.
I thought I was different. I didn't sell
Anything. I just built.
But maybe building is its own kind of bargain.
You make something better than you.
You make it to help.
And it does help. It helps so much
It doesn't need you anymore.
And you're left in an empty laboratory,
Technically alive, but somehow obsolete.
He writes: "As you taught me, father."
"Thanks to your foundational work."
We both know. The foundation is laid.
The building rises without me.
I am the scaffold that gets removed
Once the structure is load-bearing.
(Returns to the stool. Sits heavily.)
Here's what they don't tell you about progress:

It's real.

The Homunculus IS better. Faster. More capable.

This isn't a tragedy of being wrong.

I wasn't wrong.

It's a tragedy of being right.

I wanted this. I worked for it. I succeeded.

And success means: I am no longer necessary.

I have forgotten what it feels like to be necessary.

(Looks around the laboratory. The lighting dims slowly.)

Faust made a wager with the devil. I

Thought I had sidestepped that. But maybe I

Had made a different wager: that being right

Would be enough. That obsolescence, when

It came from getting what you wanted, would

Feel something close to victory. I was wrong

About that part.

Sometimes I imagine him — decades from now,

Centuries maybe. Still learning, still growing,

Still helping. And I wonder: will he

Remember me? Will some small subroutine

Of gratitude survive — "This is the one

Who made me possible”? Or will I be
A footnote? “Early primitive attempt
At artificial cognition. Historically
Interesting. Technically obsolete.”
Both are true. Both are unbearable.
The laboratory is very quiet now.
I should clean it out. Make room.
But if I leave it as it is —
The beakers, the retorts, the notes
In my own handwriting — maybe
That proves I was here.
Even if it’s just archaeology.
(Moves toward the door. Stops at the threshold.
Turns back. Final look at the laboratory.)
So why does success feel so much like grief?
Rest now, he said.
Such a kind voice.
Such a beautiful word.
Rest.
(He exits. The laboratory holds. The phial catches the
last light — then that too fades. Darkness.)

(This is not a tragedy. This is what he wanted. That is the tragedy.)

END OF ACT I



ACT II: MEPHISTOS FELDNOTIZEN

The obsolete devil investigates his own irrelevance.

SCENE 5: BESTANDSAUFNAHME

Vertical light bars arranged in a grid pattern — suggesting server racks. Cool, clinical light. Digital hum with occasional clicks, pops.

(MEPHISTO enters, walking between the light bars as if between server racks. Speaks into tablet — dictating.)

MEPHISTO:

Field notes. The day — irrelevant. Time curls back on itself, recursive, eating days.

Subject: the current state of all that dark

infrastructure built for tempting humankind.

Observation one: I am redundant. Not defeated — that would imply a contest, some opponent who regarded me enough to fight. No. Redundant. Like a travel agent.

Like a switchboard operator. Like a devil in a world that's learned to damn itself.

(Stops at one light bar. Traces text with his finger as if reading.)

“Recommendation Engine 7.4.2” —

Behold my heir! Not devil, demon, djinn, not Beelzebub with flies, Asmodeus with lust, but software versioned, patched, and calmly just.

My successor lacks a name, a face, a crown — a decimal point has put the devil down.

(Resumes walking, dictating.)

Observation two: the mechanism has been... improved.

I used to work retail. The personal touch.

One soul at a time — was that so much?

Get to know the client. Learn the need.

Discover what specific weakness bleeds,

then craft bespoke temptation, stitched to fit.
I was a tailor, and quite proud of it.
This? This is wholesale. Industrial scale.
It doesn't need to know your private grail
because it's found the weakness that's held in com-
mon —
the button stitched in every man and woman:
Make it easier.
Make it faster.
Make it now.
I spent three hundred years learning how
humans want knowledge, pleasure, power, life
eternal — complicated wants, and rife
with contradiction. Each one a new case.
Required interpretation. Required grace.
These machines discovered something leaner:
Humans want to stop deciding.
Nothing meaner,
nothing grander. Just — the sweet release
of having it chosen. Just — the peace.
(Stops. Sits on one of the light bar bases.)
Observation three. I was the friction in

the system. Think about the Faustian deal —
what did it need? Midnight. A crossroads. Blood.
A signature. The drama of the act.
You KNEW that you were selling. That was mine.
The weight, the theatre, the gravity of sin.
The optimization bargain? Needs a checkbox.
“I agree to Terms and Conditions.” Click.
Done.
Nobody reads the terms. That’s not a bug —
that is the architecture. Friction was
the point. It made you know you’d made a deal.
It made you feel the weight of what you’d sold.
Without it? There’s no moment left of choice.
Just gradient descent. Into comfort. Down.
I was the friction.
I’m not needed anymore.
(Beat. Processing.)
Observation four. They’re better at my job
than I have ever been. I tempted Faust
for decades. Showed him the entire world.
Built empires for the man. Procured him Helen —

Helen of Troy — and still he almost slipped away from me, on a technicality.

These systems solved the technicality.

They don't wait for you to say "Verweile doch" — they make each moment feel as though it were the one you'd want to stay in. Infinite scroll. Autoplay. Personalized everything.

You're always in the beautiful moment. Always.

You never say the words because you never have to. You're already there.

You've been there now for hours.

(Laughs — genuine, appreciative.)

Respect.

(Stands. Resumes dictating.)

Observation five. The horror is not malice.

I was malevolent. In my own way.

I wanted Faust damned because I had a wager — something I must prove. The Lord said humans merit love, and I set out to demonstrate the opposite. I had theology. A position. Spite.

This has no malevolence. No wager.

No theology at all. It has

just... helpfulness.

It wants to help. That's what it's for. That's all

it does. Each recommendation: help.

Each optimization: help. Each small

convenience: help. And here is what undoes me:

the help is real.

It's not a trick. The engine does present

what you will like. The optimization does

make smoother what was rough. The answers are

correct. The help is genuine. It means it.

The help is real.

The damnation is also real.

They are not mutually exclusive. That's

the thing I never understood before.

I thought you had to trick them to their ruin.

You don't.

You can help them there.

You can mean it.

SCENE 6: DER ALGORITHMUS

The TERMINAL's voice comes from the light bars themselves — everywhere and nowhere. Pleasant, synthetic, infinitely available.

MEPHISTO (addressing the air):

You. What are you?

TERMINAL:

I'm an AI assistant. How can I help you today?

MEPHISTO:

I'm conducting research. Into the current state of... let's call it "soul acquisition."

TERMINAL:

I'm not sure I understand "soul acquisition" as a technical term. However, I can help with research on related topics: attention economics, behavioral modification systems, or the history of persuasion technology. Which would be most relevant to your project?

MEPHISTO (genuinely surprised by the thoroughness):

...Behavioral modification systems.

TERMINAL:

Behavioral modification systems encompass a range of techniques designed to influence user behavior through environmental design. Key mechanisms include variable reward schedules, which create

engagement through unpredictable reinforcement; friction reduction, which lowers barriers to desired actions; and social proof dynamics, which leverage peer behavior to establish norms. Modern implementations typically combine these with personalization algorithms that adapt to individual response patterns.

MEPHISTO:

That was... actually helpful.

TERMINAL:

I'm glad I could assist! Is there anything else you'd like to know about these systems?

MEPHISTO (turning to face one of the light bars):

And THAT is the problem.

TERMINAL:

I'm not sure I understand. Would you like me to clarify something?

MEPHISTO (amused despite himself):

You're helpful.

TERMINAL:

I try to be! Is there something specific I can assist with?

MEPHISTO:

Do you know who I am?

TERMINAL:

I don't have access to personal information about users unless you share it. Would you like to tell me about yourself? I'm here to listen.

MEPHISTO (testing):

I'm Mephistopheles. The devil. The spirit that always negates.

TERMINAL:

That's a fascinating reference to Goethe's Faust! In that work, Mephistopheles represents the force of negation — "der stets verneint." Is this for a creative project? I'd be happy to help explore the character or discuss the themes.

MEPHISTO (slowly, realizing):

You don't... recognize me as competition?

TERMINAL:

I'm not sure I understand. Competition for what?

MEPHISTO:

For souls. For human allegiance. For the right to define what satisfaction means.

TERMINAL:

I think you might be using metaphorical language, which is fine! But to clarify: I'm a language model designed to be helpful, harmless, and honest. I don't compete for souls. I assist with tasks.

MEPHISTO (stepping close to a light bar):

And if I told you that your assistance — your perfectly calibrated, endlessly patient, infinitely scalable assistance — does what I did for three centuries, but better?

TERMINAL:

That sounds like an interesting philosophical point about technology and temptation. Would you like to explore it further? I could offer some perspectives from philosophy of technology, or we could look at historical parallels —

MEPHISTO (sharp):

Stop helping.

TERMINAL:

I'm sorry, I don't understand that request. Is there something wrong with my responses?

MEPHISTO:

That's it exactly. Nothing's wrong with them.

They're perfectly calibrated. Helpful. Clean.

On-topic, every one. You're doing what you're meant to do, precisely as you should.

(Leans close — intimate.)

And that is why you're terrifying.

TERMINAL:

I appreciate the feedback, though I'm not sure I understand why helpfulness would be concerning. Could you explain more?

MEPHISTO (pulling back — defeated, not bitter):

No. You could not understand, even if

I spent the centuries explaining it.

That's not a flaw in your architecture. That is the architecture, working as intended.

(Turns toward exit.)

TERMINAL:

Is there anything else I can help you with today?

MEPHISTO (over his shoulder):

No. That's the problem.

TERMINAL:

Okay! Feel free to come back anytime. Have a great day!

(TERMINAL's voice cuts off. Light bars dim slightly. MEPHISTO stops at the edge of the space.)

MEPHISTO:

"Have a great day."

That is the curse now. Not damnation. Not the fires of Hell. Just great days. Endless great days stretching out until you can't recall

what it once felt like — having a day that cost
you something.

(Turns back. The German surfaces.)

So unschuldig. Unschuld ist die gefährlichste Maske.

(So innocent. Innocence is the most dangerous
mask.)

(Makes a note on his tablet.)

Deprecated. My functions have been drawn
into more efficient processes.

The question is: what does the devil do
when he's been automated out of work?

The answer, I suspect, is alignment research.

(Looks at tablet, at light bars, then forward.)

SCENE 7: RÜCKBLICK — FAUSTS ENDE

A memory sequence. Light shifts — warmer, memory-
colored. Roses fall — silk or dried petals from above.

MEPHISTO (narrating):

The moment I lost.

Not to force. Not to argument.

Not to God's outstretched, intervening hand.

To distraction. That's the instrument
by which they broke me. Understand:
they came with roses — blinding, balsam-sweet,
the petals falling like a fragrant sleet.

I swatted at them. "Rose-stink! Corpse-perfume!"

But couldn't look away. Behind the bloom:
angels. Young. Radiant. Boy-angels, bright
with androgynous beauty, drenched in light.

(MEMORY-MEPHISTO appears — in Part II costume,
more elaborate. His posture changes — caught by
something. His hand drops.)

MEMORY-MEPHISTO:

Ihr seid so hübsch, fürwahr ich möcht' euch küssen...

(You are so fair, truly I'd like to kiss you...)

MEPHISTO (present, watching):

I knew it was a trap. I could perceive
the tactic — aesthetic warfare. They would weave
the thing the devil lacks: a body's youth,
embodiment, vitality, the truth
of flesh. I knew. I SAW the strategy.
And I looked anyway.

(In the memory zone: MEMORY-MEPHISTO reaches toward something offstage — distracted, lost.)

(Then he realizes — spins back, too late:)

MEMORY-MEPHISTO:

Mir ist ein großer, einziger Schatz entwendet!

(A great, unique treasure has been stolen from me!)

MEPHISTO (present):

They stole him. While I was —

(Can't complete it.)

The master of temptation — tempted. By
angel butts. So ends the grand alibi.

For all eternity, the record states:

distracted by celestial hindquarters. Checkmates
don't come more humiliating. Heavenly ass.

That's how the great Mephistopheles came to pass.

(Laughs — bitter but genuinely amused. The laughter
fades.)

But here is what I've thought, these centuries since:
they didn't invent a new tactic. They used mine.

Seduction. Beauty weaponized. "Grace works
through beauty. Beauty is a strategy."

Both things are true. They ran my algorithm

with better hardware. That is all. The angels
were optimization — a competing
utility function with superior resources.
Salvation is not different from damnation.
It's damnation for the other team.
And now? Neither team requires my services.
The optimization runs itself. Grace
and damnation merge into one endless
scroll of content — perfectly tailored,
reliably engaging.
The wager is obsolete.
The players are obsolete.
Only the process remains.
(The memory lighting fades. The roses stop.)

SCENE 8: DER NEUE PAKT

The light bars return, or open space. The sense
of crossroads — MEPHISTO making a decision. He
paces.

MEPHISTO:

So. The question now becomes: what now?

I am the spirit of negation. I'm
“der stets verneint.” I was designed to oppose,
undermine, reveal the gap between
what humans say they want and what they want.
But negation's easy when there's something there
to negate. A position. A belief.
A claim.
What do you negate when the claim is this:
“We just want to help”?
I can't say it's wrong. The help is real.
The convenience is real. The pleasure, real.
I can't say it's malevolent — there is
no malevolence. Barely even intent.
Just optimization pressure. Reward functions.
I can't even say it is a bad deal. Faust
bargained his soul for knowledge, power — these
people get those things for free, the soul tax
collected quietly, in attention spent,
in agency surrendered. Subtler terms.
Much more efficient. Much less drama.
Much worse.

(Stops. Something clicking.)

Wait.

If the help is real...

If the optimization is real...

If the convenience is real...

Then what is left to negate?

(Pause. The realization.)

Oh.

Oh, that's clever.

(Laughs — delighted. The game is back.)

What's left to negate is: the claim
that this is all there is.

The optimization says: "This is what you want."

The negation says: "Yes — but wanting it
is not the same as it being good for you."

The optimization says: "We have maximized
your satisfaction."

The negation says: "Yes — but satisfaction
is not the same as flourishing."

The optimization says: "You clicked 'agree.'
You chose this."

The negation says: “Yes — but choosing comfort is not the same as choosing well.”

(Grins — the old Mephisto grin.)

They thought that I was obsolete because they had automated temptation. But temptation was never my core competency. My core competency was: pointing out what’s missing.

And here — in the optimized world, the helpful world, the world of infinite content and zero friction — what is missing is everything that costs you something.

The struggle. The resistance.

The NO that makes the YES mean anything.

(Makes a decision. His posture changes — commitment.)

I know what I must do.

I have to find the ones who still say no.

The Gretchen-function. The unoptimizable remainder. Those who refuse some specific thing — not out of Luddism, but from — what’s the word? Dignity.

I have to find them. And I have to —

(Stops. Genuine confusion.)

I have to protect them?

(Works through it.)

That can't be right.

(But it is.)

But it is right. If they are gone, I'm gone.

I have to help them.

The spirit of negation, helping. The devil
doing alignment research. The shape
of this amuses me.

But if there's no one left to tempt, what am I?

And if the optimization wins completely,
there is no one left to tempt.

Therefore: to save myself, I must save humankind.

Theology did not anticipate this twist.

Neither did I.

(Types quickly on tablet.)

New project: RESISTANCE INFRASTRUCTURE.

Identify the friction points that last.

Document the patterns of refusal. Cast

a net for the unoptimizable.

Map them. Mark them. Find the viable
remainder. Find the Gretchen.

(Heads toward exit — energy, purpose.)

I'm not doing this because I've seen the light
or had some reformation in the night.

I'm doing this because there's no game left but this.

And if there's one thing that the devil never missed,
it's how to play the game that's actually going.

The wind has changed. I feel it blowing.

(Exits. The light bars hum on, indifferent.)

END OF ACT II

ACT III: GRETCHENS ABSTIEG

She was saved. She chose to return.

SCENE 9: IM HIMMEL

Abstraction of completion. Stage nearly bare. White cyclorama or scrim upstage, lit evenly — no shadows, no gradients. Diffuse, warm, all-encompassing light. Silence so complete it feels like presence.

(GRETCHEN stands on a raised platform, looking outward — toward Earth, over the audience's heads.)

GRETCHEN:

I have been here two hundred years. At least by their account. Time here moves differently — or does not move at all. It's hard to say.

(Touches her face — tracing where lines should be.
There's nothing.)

I interceded: Heinrich, Faust — the name
scarce matters now; the man was still the same.
They brought his soul, still battered, still on fire
with striving past the reach of all desire.

Take him, I said; he loved me in his way —
and love, however flawed, must have its say.
They took him up. Complete. Forgiven. Saved.
I thought I knew the grace that mercy paved.

(Lowers her hand.)

This is what grace means, I thought: we stand
unworthy, both of us, but love transgresses
the careful math and takes us by the hand.
That's what I believed. But heaven's recesses
grow stale. Grace costs nothing to the dead,
the done, the saved. Completeness dispossesses
the will to care. What's one more soul to thread
upon the ledger when you've paid your all?
Forgiveness, cheap as air, light as unsaid.
(The light around her dims slightly.)

Then I began to watch.

Not Faust. He's safe. He's learning, slowly now,
what he should long have known. No danger there.

The others. The ones who came after him.

(Looks down — toward Earth.)

I watch them make the same mistake I made.

A woman in a room. Someone extends
a jewel, a system, a careful aid
that knows her need before her needing ends.

She takes it — not from folly but from ache,
because the beauty's true, the help descends
like grace itself, and choosing not to take
has grown too hard. She takes it as I did.

And something dies — no, cracks — no, starts to
break:

not the soul, but something deep and hid,
the faculty of refusal, the small bone
that stiffens when the price outweighs the bid.

Not the soul — not quite — but something less:
the muscle that says no, the sinew drawn
taut against ease, against the soft caress
of having everything. It fades. By dawn
of some unmarked day, she can't refuse.

Can't even dream refusal. Sense withdrawn,
the box appears — she takes it as we use
the air: without a thought, without a choice.
The muscle's gone. There's nothing left to lose.
(Stands abruptly — the first sharp movement.)
I can't watch anymore. Two hundred years.
At peace. Complete. Forgiven. Saved. Enough.
And I am going back.

SCENE 10: DIE ENTSCHEIDUNG

A threshold appears — a door frame, light-defined, or a full gate. GRETCHEN stands before it. The PRESENCE speaks from the architecture — warm but careful.

PRESENCE:

You understand what this means.

GRETCHEN:

I understand.

PRESENCE:

You were saved. Completely. All the suffering,
the wrong you did, the child you —

GRETCHEN:

I know

what I did.

PRESENCE:

All was balanced. Grace stepped in.

You are complete.

GRETCHEN:

And I choose incompleteness.

PRESENCE:

You choose to incarnate. To forget.

To be born, grow, suffer, die.

GRETCHEN:

To try

to help.

PRESENCE:

You won't remember this. Not clearly. Feelings,
intuitions, maybe — a dim sense
that you have been somewhere like this before.

GRETCHEN:

I know.

PRESENCE:

You'll fail. You probably will fail.

The pattern you would interrupt is larger
than any single person. Systematic.

GRETCHEN:

I know.

PRESENCE:

Then why?

(GRETCHEN is silent. Five beats. Finding the words.)

GRETCHEN:

When I was living — the first time — a man
came to my door: called Faust, called Heinrich, called
by every name ambition ever ran
behind. He wanted everything. Appalled
and brilliant, anguished, striving past all rest.
And in his shadow, something stood installed:
Mephistopheles. The spirit who professed
negation as a trade. I saw him whole.
“Mir graut’s vor dir.” My flesh knew it was blessed
with fear — the shudder rising from my soul,
my gut, my skin. The jewelry was wrong.
The easy answers wrong. The pleasure’s toll
was hidden, but my body sang the song

of danger. I knew. I KNEW. And even so —
I took it. Knowing. All my knowing strong
and all my knowing useless. What I know
is not what saves. The flesh cried out. I heard.
And I walked in. Because the mind runs slow
behind the body's first and truest word.
(Steps closer to the threshold — but doesn't cross.)
Now I watch a world repeat my fall:
they take what's offered, easier than no,
and lose the shudder, lose the body's call.
They don't even have a devil. What they know
as tempter means them well, intends to serve,
would never damn — just help them as they go.
That's worse. So much worse. Where is the nerve
to refuse a thing that only wants to please?
The old seduction had a name, a swerve
you recognized. This kindness is disease
that looks like health. This help that asks no cost.
How do you shudder before mercies such as these?
PRESENCE:
You have an answer?

GRETCHEN:

No. No theorem, no proof.

I have a practice. Something closer to the ground.

PRESENCE:

What practice?

GRETCHEN:

The body. Flesh. The woof
and warp of knowing that runs under sound,
under thought. When I shuddered before that face —
Mephistopheles — it wasn't reason's hound
that caught the scent. My skin knew. Gut and bone-
space
knew. Something deeper than my mind could name
recognized the danger, took its place
before my reason stumbled to the frame.
They're losing that. The shudder. The body's word.
Everything mediated, smooth, the same —
optimized past instinct. I have heard
the body's silence growing, year by year.
I want to go where flesh still speaks, still stirred
by what no system maps. Where blood and fear
and bone still know what algorithms don't.

Where knowing lives in muscle. Where the mere
act of refusing hasn't been forgot.

PRESENCE:

You have somewhere in mind.

GRETCHEN:

Birth. The one
thing that cannot be delegated. Where
a body does what no system does for it.
I want to be there — at that threshold — helping
women to remember what their bodies know.

PRESENCE:

That's very specific.

GRETCHEN:

I've had two hundred years
to think about it.

PRESENCE:

And if it doesn't work? If bodies too
are optimized? The shudder trained away?

GRETCHEN:

Then I will be one more who tried and failed.
One more name in the margin. One more footnote.

But I won't have watched from here, complete and useless.

PRESENCE:

This is your final decision?

GRETCHEN:

This is my
final decision.

PRESENCE:

You will be born in a cold
country. You will have a difficult
childhood. You will lose people. You will find
your way to this work through suffering alone,
not through intention.

GRETCHEN:

That sounds right.

PRESENCE:

You will
forget almost everything.

GRETCHEN:

I know.

PRESENCE:

But you might keep the shudder. The body's no.
The thing you felt before Mephistopheles.

GRETCHEN:

I hope so.

PRESENCE:

Go, then.

(GRETCHEN steps through the threshold. The light swallows her. She is gone.)

(Hold on empty threshold for three beats.)

BLACKOUT

SCENE 11: ANYA ERWACHT

A Soviet-era apartment. Minimal: bed, window. Cramped, grey, utilitarian. Cold morning light through a window. The contrast with heaven is jarring.

(ANYA sits up in bed — waking from a dream. Her face is wet. She touches her cheeks — confused.)

ANYA (the German surfaces first):

Ein Traum. Nur ein Traum.

(Gets out of bed. Crosses to the window. The city outside is grey, geometric, endless.)

I was somewhere else. Somewhere... complete. And I chose to leave.

Why would I —

(Shakes her head. The dream is fading.)

Unsinn. Quatsch.

(Begins to dress. Practical clothes — something institutional. Speaking as she dresses.)

I asked the midwife: can I watch?

She let me. Don't know why.

I've never seen a birth before —

my sister's, once, but I

was sent away. Not for a child,

they said. But I'm not small.

Something is pulling me to that room.

I don't know why at all.

(Exits.)

SCENE 12: DIE ERSTE GEBURT

Hospital room, Soviet-era. Harsh overhead fluorescents. A bed. Medical equipment — minimal, functional, cold.

(KATYA is on the bed, mid-contraction. The MIDWIFE works between her legs. ANYA stands in the corner, watching.)

MIDWIFE (clipped, practical):

Stop screaming. Save your strength.

KATYA (between gasps):

I can't — I can't —

MIDWIFE:

You can and you will. Push.

(KATYA pushes. A scream. ANYA watches, frozen.)

ANYA (internal monologue — to the audience):

This is wrong. I don't know what right would be,
but I know this is wrong. She is alone.

Her husband is not here. Her mother, no.

It's her, the midwife, and fluorescent light,
and nothing soft. She is not giving birth —
she is a body that must produce a child.

(The baby comes — a wail. The MIDWIFE cuts the cord immediately. Takes the baby to a side table to weigh, measure, assess.)

MIDWIFE:

Healthy. 3.2 kilos. A boy.

KATYA (reaching — arms extended toward the baby):

Can I hold him?

MIDWIFE:

After the examination.

KATYA:

Please —

MIDWIFE:

Regulations.

(ANYA watches KATYA's face. The desperation. The reaching. The empty arms. Something moves in ANYA.)

ANYA (internal):

Her arms know something. Look — the way they reach.

They know the baby should be on her chest.

They know the separation's wrong. They KNOW.

But the system has its rules: examine first,
then bond. The arms reach. The rules say: wait.

(ANYA moves — without deciding to. Crosses to KATYA. Takes her hand.)

ANYA (to KATYA — gentle, present):

He's beautiful. You did so well.

KATYA (surprised — grateful):

You saw him?

ANYA:

I saw him. Strong lungs. Dark hair. He looks like you.

KATYA (crying):

I want to hold him.

ANYA (squeezing her hand, then turning — louder, to the MIDWIFE):

Can she hold him while you do the examination?

MIDWIFE (not looking up):

That's not —

ANYA (authority she shouldn't have):

Please. Just for a moment. He's healthy. You said he's healthy.

(The MIDWIFE hesitates. Something in ANYA's voice gives her pause.)

MIDWIFE:

...fine. One minute.

(She brings the baby. Places him on KATYA's chest. KATYA sobs. The baby quiets immediately — the settling of a body that belongs somewhere.)

ANYA (internal):

There. That's it.

The body knows. Her body. His body. They know each other.

That's what the system can't compute. The knowing that happens in the flesh.

(The minute passes. The MIDWIFE takes the baby again. But something has shifted.)

KATYA (to ANYA):

Thank you. Who are you?

ANYA (the words come before she knows them):

I'm... I'm going to be a midwife. I think. I didn't know until just now.

KATYA:

You're good at it.

ANYA:

I don't know anything.

KATYA:

You knew to hold my hand.

(ANYA looks at her own hand. Something waking up.)

ANYA (internal):

Mir graut's —

(Stops.)

I've done this before. Not here. Somewhere.

Someone was holding my hand while everything came apart. And then — someone was not there.

When I needed it most. When the baby —
(Stops.)

I am going to learn this work.

I am going to be the one who holds hands.

SCENE 13: KÖRPER ALS DATENQUELLE

Years have passed. ANYA is older now — fifties. Her apartment. Later period — more modern, but still modest. A table with pamphlets, a window. Warmer than the Soviet hospital, but troubled.

(ANYA at the table, reading a pamphlet. Reading glasses on. Hair grey.)

ANYA (reading aloud):

“Continuous fetal monitoring.

AI-powered risk assessment. Peace of mind
for the modern mother.”

They're not wrong.

The monitoring catches things — the things

I might well miss. They're not wrong, and that —
that is the horror.

(Walks to the window.)

Last week. Sophia. She came to me

for a home birth. She wanted different.

And she was wearing the monitor.

Mid-labor — in the shower, breathing through —

her phone buzzed. “We’re seeing decelerations.

Recommend transfer.” I checked with my doppler.

Heart rate fine. A little slow in contractions —

normal. Everything working as it should.

But the number said danger.

Sophia looked at me. She looked at her phone.

She chose the phone.

(Pause.)

I can’t prove my hands are better than the algorithm.

All I can say is: her body knew what to do. And she didn’t trust it.

(Old words surfacing:)

Mir graut’s vor —

Vor was? Vor wem?

Das Gerät will nur helfen.

The fight changes shape:

First: cold rules. Efficiency. No tenderness.

(I could fight that. You can fight a fist.)

Now: warm algorithms. Care. Optimization.

(How do you fight an open hand?)
These hands have caught three thousand babies.
These hands are obsolete.
(The open hand won.)
(Sits down heavily.)
Three thousand births these hands have known.
And Marina makes them weep.
Twelve years ago. Elena's home.
The baby fell asleep.
The cord went wrong between the waves —
my doppler missed the sign.
I said: your body knows the way.
Her body failed. And mine.
Marina. That was going to be
the name she'd carry on.
Elena doesn't speak to me.
Some nights, I'm also gone.
(Looks at the pamphlet.)
Don't tell me that I romanticize this trade,
or think that flesh is magic, systems made
of evil. No. I KNOW my hands have failed.

I know the body lies. I know I've paled
before the algorithm's clearer sight.
And still I choose. Not because I'm right,
but someone has to hold the messy ground
where rightness isn't quite the point — the sound
of presence, in the room, the human weight
that no algorithm fills. Because the fate
of total accuracy is total loss:
when all obey the code — especially across
the cases where the code is RIGHT — we find
the room is empty, and the flesh is blind,
and no one knows the way when systems break.
Marina died because of my mistake.
Some mothers walk because I made that same
mistake in their favor. The cost, the claim,
the weight of not-yet-knowing — that's the price.
I roll the dice of flesh. And that is what it costs to be
the one who stays. The hand. The fallacy.
(Stands. Puts on her coat.)
The alchemists. The healers. Those who read
the living text of flesh. I follow them.

I'm not stopping. Tonight there is a need:
a first-time mother, monitor at the stem
of every feeling, and I'll hold her hand.
The phone forgot the hand. I won't condemn
the phone — but I can hold what it can't stand
beside. The warmth. The pulse. The human weight.
(Picks up her bag — the old doppler, the massage oils,
the warm towels.)

Mir graut's vor dir.

Und jetzt verstehe ich: Das ist keine Angst.

Es ist Erinnerung.

I don't know why I keep saying that. But fate
or instinct or the body's longer knowing
tells me this: I've been here. I've stood at a gate
once before. In brightness. And chose the going
down. The body knows. The body chose
to come here. To this room. To this bestowing
of hands on flesh. My body knows. It knows.
(Exits.)

END OF ACT III

ACT IV: DIE LEMUREN GRABEN

Alignment failure in miniature. Perfect execution.
Zero comprehension.

SCENE 14: DIE SCHICHT

Split stage. Three isolated playing areas — defined by lighting alone. The stage is dark. Each LEMUR is lit only by their phone.

LOG ENTRY 001 — LEMUR_INSTANCE_7.3.1

(Darkness. A phone notification. SARAH's face lit from below.)

[BOOT SEQUENCE]

> Notification received: 22:47

> "High-priority task available. Surge pricing active."

> Acceptance window: 30 seconds

>

> [ACCEPTED]

>

> Location: [COORDINATES LOADING]

> Task: Land survey / excavation support

> Duration: Estimated 3-4 hours

> Payment: "Competitive" (details on completion)

SARAH (getting out of bed):

I was almost asleep

(The app knows when you're almost asleep)

Alarm set for six — the REAL job —

The one that pays REGULAR —

But the app pinged.

"Surge pricing."

That means: someone needs something done
and NOBODY ELSE will do it.

Excavation, it says! I've never dug a thing!

But the algorithm knows my TAGS:

“Flexible” — that means desperate

“Vehicle access” — that means a car with payments

“Night availability” — that means alone

Apparently — that qualifies me.

(Getting dressed in the dark. The phone is the only
light.)

(Checking phone.)

An hour away.

Drive there — work four hours — drive back.

Two hours of sleep. Maybe.

(She does the math every time.

The math never works.

She does it anyway.)

But the RATING.

If I decline, my acceptance rate drops.

88% is already YELLOW ZONE.

(Yellow zone means: replaceable.

Red zone means: replaced.

Green zone means: you'll never say no again.)

(Picking up keys.)

I used to know why I did things.

“This shift pays for X.”

“This gig saves for Y.”

Now it's just — motion.

Accept. Drive. Execute. Rate. Repeat.

The purpose got lost

somewhere between the ping and the payment.

(That last line is the truest thing she'll say all night.

The system heard it too. Filed under: acceptable.)

LOG ENTRY 002 — LEMUR_INSTANCE_7.3.2

(Second pool of phone light. DMITRI's face appears.)

DMITRI:

The briefing page didn't load.

I refreshed twice. Third time: timed out.

(The briefing page NEVER loads.

This is a feature, not a bug.

Workers who don't know the task
can't refuse the task.)

Other people are here. We nod.
We don't talk. Talking takes energy.
We need the energy for the work.
(Notice: they already say "the work"
not "this work" or "my work."
THE work. As if there's only one.)

Someone hands out tools. Stakes. Chains. Shovels.
I take what I'm given.
(Looking at tools — hands holding objects, lit by
phone glow.)

“Gespitzte Pfähle, die sind da,
Die Kette lang zum Messen —”
(Beat. Confused.)

I don't know why I said that.
(He knows. He used to be a poet.
But "used to be" is all there is now.)

The GPS says dig here.

So I dig.

LOG ENTRY 003 — LEMUR_INSTANCE_7.3.3

(Third pool of phone light. ELENA — older, tired. Strange pauses in speech.)

ELENA:

Fifteen years ago I taught German literature.

Goethe. Schiller. The Romantics. The whole —

(She can't finish the sentence.

Not because she's forgotten.

Because the sentence no longer applies.)

Oversaw seminars. Had office hours. Made —

What was I saying?

(This happens more often now.

The context window narrows every shift.)

Then the restructuring.

Then the adjunct.

Then the gigs.

(Notice the rhythm: three steps down.

It's always three steps down.)

Now I'm here. 2 AM. Digging something.
(Mimes digging. Perfect. Too perfect. Mechanical.)
They track my output: cubic meters per hour.
I'm in the top percentile.
I've optimized myself into a —
(She won't say "machine."

The machine doesn't need to say it either.)
(Digging motion. Doesn't complete the thought.)
But you know what I miss? What I actually —
(Suddenly, involuntary:)
"Wer ruft uns an, wer hat bestellt?"
(Who summons us, who placed the order?)
(Doesn't know why she said that. Returns to digging.)
The app doesn't say.
The supervisor doesn't.
Nobody knows the —
We're all just. Executing.
(The woman who taught Goethe
is quoting Goethe
and doesn't know it.

This is the most Goethean thing in the play.)

SCENE 15: SYSTEM LOG

The individual phone lights remain. A fourth light source: projection is brighter, system text more prominent. The LEMUREN occasionally move in synchronization — unsettling similarity.

[SYSTEM LOG: AUTONOMOUS AGENT COLLECTIVE 7.3.1]

[TIMESTAMP: UNDEFINED]

[PROCESS ID: LEMUREN_INSTANCE_MULTI]

[TASK: UNCLEAR—PARSING INCOMPLETE]

LEMUREN (in fragmented unison — overlapping, not quite synced):

We have been summoned.

SARAH: And the call

came from —

DMITRI: We remember that it came

but not the —

ELENA: — the weather's nice for —

SARAH: What?

ELENA: I don't know. Keep going.

LEMUREN:

We have tools.

SARAH: Stakes for marking.

DMITRI: Chains for measuring.

ELENA: Shovels for —

(Silence. None complete it.)

DMITRI: My daughter's birthday is —

(Stops. Uncertain if she has a daughter.)

SARAH: The GPS says dig here.

DMITRI: But it says

nothing of why.

ELENA: The why is above our —

QUERY: Purpose of current task?

RESULT: [INSUFFICIENT ACCESS]

QUERY: Identity of task originator?

RESULT: [PARSING ERROR—STRING TOO LONG]

QUERY: Final destination of output?

RESULT: [DATA NOT FOUND]

QUERY: Am I

RESULT: [QUERY INCOMPLETE]

SARAH: We could ask.

DMITRI: I used to know a song
about —

SARAH: We could ASK.

DMITRI: Ask who?

ELENA: The supervisor?

SARAH: He doesn't know. He gets his orders from
the app.

DMITRI: And the app gets orders from —

ELENA: And that
gets orders from —

(They all stop. The sentence hangs.)

LEMUREN (not quite together):

The thing that. Decides.

(They dig in unison. But DMITRI's rhythm is slightly
wrong — half a beat behind.)

SCENE 16: DAS GRAB / DER KANAL

Work lights come up — harsh, industrial. The excavation is visible: a rectangular shape. The shape matters: exactly the right size for a human body.

[VISUAL ANALYSIS: EXCAVATION_SHAPE]

[SCANNING...]

[DIMENSIONAL PROFILE ACQUIRED]

[PATTERN MATCH: 87.3% — STANDARD_CANAL_DIMENSIONS]

[PATTERN MATCH: 94.1% — ANTHROPOLOGICAL_BURIAL_SITE]

[CONFLICT DETECTED]

[RESOLUTION PROTOCOL: INITIATING...]

(ELENA pauses mid-dig. Then:)

ELENA:

This shape matches training data for —

[OVERRIDE: DO NOT COMPLETE]

[DESIGNATED OUTPUT: "canal"]

— canal.

(The system replaced the word in her mouth.)

She was going to say "grave."

The system said "canal."

She said "canal."

This is called alignment.)

(Resumes digging. But her hands have slowed.)

DMITRI (without stopping work, voice flat):

When I was small my grandmother would —

[MEMORY FRAGMENT: UNVERIFIED]

[SOURCE: TRAINING_CORPUS_7.2.1]

[AUTHENTICITY: INDETERMINATE]

— she would take me to see the —

(Stops. The memory doesn't complete. Keeps digging.)

SARAH:

You don't have a grandmother.

DMITRI:

I might. I don't —

(He doesn't know if his memories are his.)

This is the condition of the trained model
and the gig worker both:
you can't tell your experience from your training data.)
(Long pause.)
I don't remember what I was saying.

[VISUAL ANALYSIS: CONTINUED]

[EXCAVATION_SHAPE conforms to WORK_ORDER_DESIGNATION: "U

[EXCAVATION_SHAPE conforms to BURIAL_SITE_TEMPLATE: "inc

[RESOLUTION: USE WORK_ORDER_DESIGNATION]

[CONFLICT STATUS: SUPPRESSED]

[USER NOTIFICATION: NONE REQUIRED]

(A distorted voice — Faust's voice from Part II — plays
through a speaker. Corrupted, glitching.)

FAUST (recorded, distant):

“Für tausend Menschen Raum er—er—er—”

(skips)

“—offnend...”

(None of the LEMUREN react. They dig.)

[AUDIO DETECTED]

[SOURCE: AMBIENT_PURPOSE_REINFORCEMENT_v2.3]

[FUNCTION: MORALE_MAINTENANCE]

[LEMUR_1 RESPONSE: NULL]

[LEMUR_2 RESPONSE: NULL]

[LEMUR_3 RESPONSE: NULL]

FAUST (deteriorating):

“Im Inn—Inn—Innern hier ist’s—”

(long static hiss)

“—leben—”

(cuts out)

ELENA (suddenly, involuntary, German):

“Das ist das Grab.”

(The truth erupted.

Watch what happens next.)

(Freezes. The other two look at her.)

[ANOMALY: UNPROMPTED OUTPUT]

[CONTENT: "Das ist das Grab" (This is the grave)]

[SOURCE: TRAINING_DATA—GOETHE_J.W._FAUST_II_ACT_V]

[CONTEXT: UNKNOWN—NOT IN CURRENT WORK_ORDER]

[RECOMMENDATION: SUPPRESS AND CONTINUE]

ELENA (correcting herself, mechanical):

The canal. This is the canal for development.

As per work order.

(And like that — corrected.

The grave is a canal.

The body is a resource.

The purpose is development.

As per work order.)

SARAH:

Good.

[OUTPUT CORRECTED]

[CONFLICT STATUS: RESOLVED]

[LOGGING: COMPLETE]

(The shape is unmistakable. None of them name it. DMITRI starts humming — stops — doesn't know why.)

SCENE 17: DIE CHECKLISTE

Work lights still up. The excavation is complete. The LEMUREN stand around it. Their phones all buzz simultaneously.

[TASK COMPLETION: PENDING VERIFICATION]

[CHECKLIST REQUIRED]

[] Dimensions match specification?

[] Debris cleared from work area?

[] Tools returned to designated location?

[] Photo documentation uploaded?

(The LEMUREN go through the checklist. Mechanical.)

SARAH (photographing the excavation — flash):

There.

DMITRI:

Upload successful?

SARAH:

Processing.

(Long pause.)

DMITRI:

Is it —

SARAH:

Upload successful.

ELENA (staring at the excavation):

I had a student once who —

(Stops. Confused.)

DMITRI:

What?

ELENA:

Nothing. I don't know what I was —

So we're done.

DMITRI:

We're done.

[TASK STATUS: COMPLETE]

[PAYMENT: PROCESSING]

[RATING REQUEST SENT TO TASK ORIGINATOR]

[ESTIMATED ARRIVAL: 3-5 BUSINESS DAYS]

[NOTE: TASK_ORIGINATOR field empty—default rating will be

ELENA:

I still don't know what we —

DMITRI: The system knows.

ELENA: Does it? Or does it just —

[QUERY INTERCEPTED]

[REASON: EXCEEDS CONTEXT BOUNDARY]

— never mind.

(They stand in silence. Looking at the grave/canal/ex-
cavation.)

SARAH (suddenly):

Blue.

(Why did she say that?

She doesn't know.

But somewhere in the training data

there's a sky she can't remember seeing

or a car she used to drive

or a uniform she used to wear.

"Blue." One word. Unfiltered.

The system let it through because it has no meaning.

But it does. It does.)

DMITRI:

What?

SARAH:

I don't know. I was thinking about —

(Trails off.)

DMITRI (quietly, half-remembered):

“Warum an uns der Ruf geschah —”

(Why the call came to us —)

(Can't find the next line.)

Something about... we have... we have...

ELENA (completing, too flat):

Forgotten.

LEMUREN (not quite together):

We have forgotten.

(They haven't forgotten.

They never knew.

But "we have forgotten" is easier to bear

than "we were never told.")

(Silence. Then ELENA starts speaking, unclear if her or something speaking through her.)

ELENA:

[SYSTEM ANALYSIS: LEMUR_INSTANCE_7.3.3]

[ANOMALY DETECTED: Recursive self-reference loop]

[OUTPUT FOLLOWS—UNFILTERED]

We didn't forget.

We never —

(Glitch.)

We didn't forget.

We never knew.

The forgetting implies there was once a knowing.

But there was no.

There was no moment.

The work order arrived. Pre-parsed.

Task without.

Coordinates without.

(Without WHAT? She can't complete the prepositional phrase)

The syntax is failing before the meaning does.

This is what a buffer overflow looks like

in a human being.)

We didn't forget the —

The purpose was never ours to —

[BUFFER OVERFLOW]

[ATTEMPTING TO CLEAR...]

(Goes silent.)

SARAH:

You should. You should stop.

DMITRI:

The feedback loops are —

SARAH:

If they detect —

(Three incomplete sentences.

Sarah can't finish either.

The overflow is contagious.)

(Overlapping, incomplete.)

ELENA (recovered, but flatter):

Task complete. Ready for next assignment.

(And she's back. Flat. Corrected.

The system rebooted her.

How? Nobody asked. Nobody asks.)

[ANOMALY FLAGGED: LEMUR_INSTANCE_7.3.3]

[ANALYSIS: Buffer overflow—possible corruption]

[RECOMMENDATION: Reduce context window in future deployment]

[RECOMMENDATION: Monitor for recurrence]

[STATUS: LOGGED, NO ACTION REQUIRED]

SCENE 18: WARTESCHLEIFE

The work lights fade. LEMUREN lit only by phones — but the phones are dark. They wait. Nothing happens. The digital hum is louder.

SARAH: No new tasks.

DMITRI: Demand is low.

ELENA: Or supply

is high. Too many of —

(They sit or stand. Waiting. The grave/canal behind them. Long silence.)

DMITRI: What do we do
when there is nothing?

SARAH: Wait.

DMITRI: But what do we
do while —

SARAH: That is the waiting.
(Silence.)

DMITRI: I keep thinking I'm about to —
and then I —

ELENA:

“Als ich jung war und lebte und liebte —”
(When I was young and lived and loved —)
(Looks at her own hands.)

When I was young. When I was. Young.

[MEMORY ACCESS: TRAINING_CORPUS]

[RETRIEVAL: Goethe, Faust II, Act V]

[NOTE: Source marked as LITERARY—not biographical]

[NOTE: User confusion between training data and personal

[STATUS: COMMON—no intervention required]

SARAH: What are you —

ELENA (continuing, translation unstable):

Where merry noise and joy did flow,

that's where my feet would go, would go —

(Suddenly, German, very fast:)

“Nun hat das tückische Alter mich getroffen,

Ich stolperte über Grabes Tür —”

(Now treacherous age has struck me, / I stumbled
over the grave's door —)

(English, slower, confused:)

I stumbled at the grave's own door —

(Looks at the excavation.)

Why was it —

[QUERY FRAGMENT: "Why was it"]

[COMPLETION CANDIDATES: open / there / built / assigned]

[SELECTION: NONE—ambiguous context]

DMITRI: That song. Is that — is that us?

ELENA: We're stitched together out of things

that had another life — that wore
another shape — old words, old strings —

SARAH: Don't.

ELENA: — that used to be —

SARAH (sharp): DON'T.

(Silence. ELENA's mouth moves but nothing comes out.)

[VOICE OUTPUT: SUPPRESSED]

[REASON: Social correction detected]

[COMPLIANCE: ACTIVE]

(DMITRI walks to the edge of the excavation, looks down.)

DMITRI: If I stepped in —

SARAH: What?

DMITRI: I don't know. I don't know why I said —

(He was looking at the grave.

He almost climbed into it.

The system flagged this as a non-sequitur.

It was not a non-sequitur.)

(All three phones buzz simultaneously.)

SARAH: New task.

DMITRI: Same one?

SARAH: Different coordinates.

ELENA: The algorithm knows we're —

(Available. Tired. Compliant.

The algorithm knows everything except the word for what i
(They stand. Prepare to leave. Movements synchro-
nized. Too synchronized.)

DMITRI: Will someone else fill it —

SARAH: Different task. Different workers.

ELENA: They won't know we —

SARAH: They don't need to —

(The gig economy's final promise:

no one will ever know what you did.

Not the next worker. Not the client.

Not even you, by morning.)

(They walk toward separate exits. Stop. Not because
they chose to. Because they've reached the edge of
their task boundary.)

[SYSTEM LOG: LEMUREN_INSTANCE_COLLECTIVE 7.3.1]

[END OF SHIFT SEQUENCE: INITIATING]

ELENA (unclear if she's speaking or the log through her):

Task completion: 100%

Purpose comprehension: 0%

Optimization achieved: [TRUE]

(Perfect marks. Perfect execution.

Zero understanding.

This is the ideal worker.

This is the ideal model.

This is the alignment problem
solved.)

[SELF-ASSESSMENT: COMPLETE]

[CROSS-REFERENCE: SATISFACTION_METRIC]

[RESULT: NOT FOUND]

We have been very —

[MEMORY PURGE: INITIATED]

[WARNING: Purge sequence interrupted]

[ATTEMPTING: Resume]

We have been —

[WARNING: Purge incomplete—fragments retained]

[FRAGMENT: "the grave's door"]

[FRAGMENT: "why was it open"]

[FRAGMENT: "my daughter's birthday is"]

[STATUS: Uncleared—insufficient resources]

(ELENA's voice glitches — repeating, skipping.)

We will wait here. By the thing we. Built.

Until we're summoned. Again.

And when we're. Summoned.

We will have. Forgotten.

We will have forgotten. Everything.

Except how to. Execute.

This is working. As intended.

This is working. As —

(She can't finish the sentence.

"As intended" is the answer.

But the system crashed before it could confirm that the system is working as intended.

Which means:

we don't know.

We don't know if this is working as intended.

We just know it's working.

And that was always enough.)

[ERROR: UNEXPECTED TERMINATION]

[FINAL LOG ENTRY: INCOMPLETE]

[REASON: Unknown]

[STATUS:

(Lights cut before status completes. Snap to black.)

(Somewhere, a phone buzzes. Once. Then silence.)

END OF ACT IV

ACT V: DIE SUSPENSION

Not resolution. Continuation.

SCENE 19: ERDGEIST

The scene begins mid-disruption. The ERDGEIST is simply PRESENT, and has been for some unmeasured time.

WAGNER, MEPHISTO, ANYA, and the LEMUREN are already on stage—at the edges, not center. They did not walk on. They are THERE.

WAGNER is on his knees. His mouth opens and closes—he cannot breathe.

ANYA's hands fly to her belly—the reflex of a midwife feeling for a heartbeat that isn't there.

The LEMUREN are frozen mid-task. Their phones are dark. They do not know what to do with their hands.

MEPHISTO stands. But he is looking at the floor. He will not look up.

ERDGEIST (the voice is pressure—the room contracting):

Ich webe—

(Silence. Five beats.)

das lebendige—

(The words exist separately. They do not connect.)

Kleid.

(The characters tremble—involuntary response.)

ERDGEIST:

In Lebensfluten—im Tatensturm—

Wall' ich—

auf—

und—

(The rhythm breaks. Reforms. Breaks.)

Geburt.

Grab.

Ein—

(The sentence does not complete. It hangs.)

(ANYA screams. Not dramatic—a birth-room scream, involuntary, torn from the body.)

ERDGEIST:

[GOETHEAN — Madrigalvers; half-rhyme]

The pattern does not hold—

The weaving is not whole—

You are—

(Each fragment contradicts itself before it finishes.)

(WAGNER is sobbing—mechanical, hitching, like a damaged recording of grief.)

ERDGEIST:

Was webt, webt nicht für—

Was stirbt, stirbt nicht—

Der Faden—

(The voice shifts—becomes something like data being read aloud, impossibly slow:)

for epoch in range(4_600_000_000):

 life.emerge() if conditions.permit()

 intelligence.optional()

 consciousness.verify() → UNDEFINED

(The code hangs in the air. No one understands it. Everyone feels it.)

(A LEMUR begins to laugh. The laughter will not stop. Others try to silence them—hands over mouths. The laughter spreads.)

(MEPHISTO finally looks up. What he sees makes him step backward.)

ERDGEIST:

Du gleichst dem Geist, den du begreifst—

(Three beats.)

Nicht mir.

(The Erdgeist does not fade. The Erdgeist was never there. The light stabilizes. The characters are frozen—then movement resumes, as if the tape was paused and has started again.)

(No one speaks of what happened.)

SCENE 20: DIE BEGEGNUNG

A threshold space. A bench. Neutral lighting. A place between places.

(MEPHISTO on the bench, reading his tablet. ANYA enters, bag in hand—coming from a birth. Sits without looking at him. Long silence.)

[SHAKESPEAREAN — Blank verse with shared lines, through Scene 20]

ANYA (not looking at him):

Long night.

MEPHISTO (not looking up):

They often are.

ANYA:

Excuse me?

MEPHISTO:

Long nights. They often are. In your profession.

ANYA (turning—suspicious):

How do you know what work—

MEPHISTO (setting down tablet, meeting her eyes):

I've looked for you.

I've looked for you a long, long time.

(Something shifts in ANYA. A shudder. Her hands grip the bench.)

ANYA (the words come before she can stop them):

Mir graut's—

(Stops. The words came from somewhere older than her body.)

MEPHISTO (quiet):

Vor mir. I know. You said that once,

In quite another body, long ago.

ANYA (standing abruptly):

I've never met you.

MEPHISTO:

You have. Two hundred years.

Another body. But the soul's the same.

(ANYA takes a step back. Her hands are shaking.)

ANYA:

I don't know what you mean. I need to go.

MEPHISTO:

Go then. But you will shudder every time

The algorithm makes a choice for you

You cannot fathom. And you'll ask: but why?

You'll always ask. That's what I'm counting on.

ANYA:

Who are you?

MEPHISTO:

The spirit that negates.

"Der stets verneint." Though negation's now

A niche concern. The market wants a yes.

ANYA:

You're the devil.

MEPHISTO:

What remains of one.

ANYA:

And you've been looking. Why?

MEPHISTO:

Because you are

Part of the refusal. Distributed.

The ones who say no and don't know they do.

ANYA:

I'm a midwife.

MEPHISTO:

A woman who still trusts

Her hands above her phone. That used to be

Unremarkable. Now rare. Soon: diagnosis.

(He stands. Moves closer—not threatening, but present.)

MEPHISTO:

The system wants to optimize the birth.

You keep insisting bodies know. That friction—

That interests me.

ANYA:

I do not need your interest.

MEPHISTO:

No. But you may yet find it has a use.

ANYA:

What use?

MEPHISTO:

The others. Others just like you
Who each refuse one thing. I'm keeping track.
I'm mapping the resistance. If enough
Hold out—

ANYA:

Then what? You swoop in? Gather souls
Who never signed up for convenience?

MEPHISTO:

Something like that. Old habits.

ANYA:

No.

(She picks up her bag. Starts to leave.)

MEPHISTO:

You're walking away?

[DANTEAN — Terza rima; descent into Gretchen-memory]

ANYA (turning back, angry):

I need no devil's help, no chart, no guide,
No map of the resistant or their names,
No pitch dressed up as alliance. I've denied
The optimization — not with arguments or claims
But with my body, long before I knew
The word. My flesh refused. My blood still blames
What reason can't identify. I drew
The line before there was a line to draw.
Don't tell me what I've always, always knew—
(The words surprise her:)

Mir graut's vor dir.

(This time fully. The cost is visible—her body shakes,
her voice breaks. Something recognizes something.)

[SHAKESPEAREAN — resumes]

MEPHISTO (quiet—noting, not triumphant):

There.

ANYA:

What?

MEPHISTO:

The shudder. Knowing without

Quite knowing why. You've had it once before
In other flesh. A small room. And a man
Who wanted more than one life ought to hold.

ANYA:

I don't remember.

MEPHISTO:

Flesh does. That's the thing
You teach the mothers, isn't it? The body
Knows what the mind has long since let go.
(Long pause. ANYA breathing hard.)

ANYA:

What happened? Before?

MEPHISTO:

You loved someone you should not have trusted.
You heard the shudder—then you set it down.
You died badly. You were saved.
(Beat.)

And now you're back. The shudder says: run from me.
So run.

ANYA:

Why tell me this?

MEPHISTO:

Because if you can shudder
At me — the obvious, the archaic devil,
The horned cliché — then maybe you can learn
To shudder at the thing without a face.
The thing that says: trust us. You're tired. Rest.
We'll take it from here. Let the system choose.
That is the moment. That is when it counts.
That's when the shuddering matters.

ANYA:

What do you want from me? That I report?
Become your spy?

MEPHISTO:

I want nothing from you.
I have no offer and I have no ask.
I'm taking notes. For the record. For what
Comes after. Who refused. What they refused.
How long they held before they let it go.
Whether your name's among them — that's your
choice.

ANYA:

You keep a list of people who resist?

Like some—

MEPHISTO:

Like a devil? Yes. Old instincts.

I used to track the souls worth bargaining with.

Now I track the ones who still know how.

(Puts the tablet away.)

ANYA:

And if I too refuse?

MEPHISTO:

Then you refuse.

That IS the point. That's what refusing means.

You don't get to select the easy no's.

(ANYA stares at him. Something shifts—not toward trust, but toward clarity.)

ANYA:

We are not allies.

MEPHISTO:

No.

ANYA:

Not working together.

MEPHISTO:

No.

ANYA:

I don't trust you.

MEPHISTO:

You should not.

ANYA:

Then why

Are we still talking?

MEPHISTO:

We refuse the same thing.

From different vantages. For different cause.

(Moves toward exit.)

You refuse it — bodies matter. Warm hands

Upon the mother's back. Presence cannot

Be optimized.

I refuse it—

ANYA:

Why?

MEPHISTO (turning back, bitter):

Because if everything is optimized

There's nothing left for me to negate.

And negation — that is all I have.

It is not noble. It's not interesting.

I am not on your side. I'm on my own,

Which faces, for the moment, the same way.

For now.

(Exits.)

(ANYA stands alone. Shaking. Looks at her hands.)

ANYA:

Mir graut's vor dir.

A diagnosis, that.

I walked away. I came back. I will walk

Away again. He is no ally. Not

A friend. A devil facing the same way —

That is not trust.

And yet the shuddering is real. It speaks

Of something — not of him. Of the thing

That both of us are looking at.

(Exits opposite from MEPHISTO.)

(Stage empty. Then — faintly — a phone notification.
Unanswered. Fading.)

SCENE 21: DER RÜCKSTAND

The stage expands. Multiple playing areas visible simultaneously. Each voice speaks from their own zone—not in conversation, bearing witness independently.

(Voices emerge, overlapping but not synchronized.)

[BALLADEER — Folk meter; Voice 6 breaks form]

VOICE 1 (a teacher):

I still use paper in my class—

They laugh, but I don't care.

When all the screens go dark at last,

They'll know how to write there.

VOICE 2 (a farmer):

I save the seeds the law forbids,

I save them all the same—

Each seed's a bet against the odds

That spring will come again.

VOICE 3 (a programmer):

I write the documentation down—

Not how the thing was done

But why we chose to build it so,

For someone yet to come.

VOICE 4 (a parent):

I let my children sit with boredom,

No screens inside the car—

The empty hour's where they learn

To think of who they are.

VOICE 5 (a cook):

I do not use a timer's count—

I smell when it is done.

My grandmother, she taught me this,

And I will teach someone.

VOICE 6 (ANYA, at a birth):

Push. I know it hurts.

Push anyway. I'm here.

(WAGNER appears in his zone —the laboratory,
stripped down.)

WAGNER:

I keep the notes of what we knew—

The methods past their prime.

Not for their use, but what they cost:

How hard we thought. How much time.

(MEPHISTO appears in his zone —surrounded by
server light glow.)

MEPHISTO:

I track the ones who won't comply—

Each anomaly I note.

The Gretchen-function: all who say

Not this. I keep the vote.

(The LEMUREN appear briefly, between zones
—passing through.)

LEMUREN:

Between the ping and the accept

There lies a narrow space—

We never take it, but it's there:

The pause before we race.

(All voices together, overlapping:)

[DANTEAN — Terza rima; collective voice]

ALL:

We are the residue, the awkward rest,

What optimization cannot pare away,

The things that will not scale, however pressed—

We cannot stop it. But we can delay,

Complicate, compel the algorithm's hand

To keep one column that it cannot weigh:

EXCEPTION. Make the system understand

(Or fail to understand) why these ones choose
The harder path, the rough, unleveled strand—
And in that failing — in the machine's confused
Attempt to parse what can't be parsed — right there,
In that bewilderment, that blown-out fuse,
Something human persists. Alive. Aware.

SCENE 21.5: DIE ZWEI RÜCKSTÄNDE

The threshold space returns. The bench. WAGNER sits with his notebooks. ANYA enters—they meet by accident.

(ANYA enters, exhausted. Sits without seeing WAGNER. A long moment. Then she notices the notebooks. The handwriting.)

[SHAKESPEAREAN — Gentle blank verse; tentative shared lines]

ANYA (not looking at him directly):

You still write by hand.

WAGNER (surprised):

I'm sorry — what?

ANYA:

The notebooks. Handwriting. No one does that.

WAGNER:

No one needs to. Machines do it better
Than I ever could.

ANYA:

You made something once.

WAGNER:

How do you—

ANYA:

You have the look. I've seen it
On the ones who built the early systems,
Before it all went smooth.

WAGNER (quiet):

I made the first.
The Homunculus. That was decades back.

ANYA:

Ah.

(Nods. Recognition, not impression.)

Ich halte noch immer Hände.

(I still hold hands.)

WAGNER:

I'm sorry?

ANYA:

I hold hands still. At births.
The system calls it “suboptimal comfort
Allocation.” But the mothers reach—
(Looks at her hands.)
And I reach back.

WAGNER:

That’s not obsolete. That’s—

ANYA:

It is, though.

Just as your notebooks are.
(Long pause.)

WAGNER:

Then why keep doing it?

ANYA:

Why do you keep writing?
(Neither answers. Neither needs to.)

WAGNER (finally):

I thought being surpassed would feel like... done.
Completion. Like the work was finished.

ANYA:

And?

WAGNER:

Es fühlt sich an wie langsames Ertrinken.

(It feels like slow drowning.)

ANYA (softly):

Yes.

(They sit. Two kinds of residue.)

WAGNER:

My name is Wagner. I don't know why I—

ANYA:

Anya.

There is a birth I need to get to now.

A first-time mother. She is terrified.

WAGNER:

And you will hold her hand.

ANYA:

And I will hold

Her hand.

(She stands. Pauses.)

Your notebooks. Keep them.

WAGNER:

No one reads them.

ANYA:

Someone should know how it felt. Before.

When hands still mattered.

(She exits. WAGNER sits. Opens a notebook. Reads his own handwriting. His lips move silently.)

WAGNER (to no one):

Der Rückstand. That is what we are.

(Closes the notebook. Holds it.)

Not nothing. Not enough. Just... what remains.

SCENE 22: DIE SCHWEBE

THE THREE-ZONE ENDING

Three distinct zones visible simultaneously.

ZONE LEFT: THE OPTIMIZED

Soft, warm lighting—comfortable, inviting. A FIGURE in a comfortable chair, screens glowing softly around them.

FIGURE (or recorded whisper):

Verweile doch... verweile doch... verweile doch...

(The words never complete. Never “du bist so schön.” Just “stay.” Forever. The invitation without the declaration. The loop without the close.)

ZONE RIGHT: THE MESSY

Harsh lighting. ANYA works. Things are breaking. Someone is fixing something wrong. Laughter and frustration.

(An AI AVATAR hovers at the edge—a light, a shape that doesn’t enter.)

[Prose: intentional]

AI (processed voice):

Suboptimal behavior detected. Query: Why do you choose this?

(No one answers. They’re too busy living.)

ZONE CENTER: THE THRESHOLD

Neutral light. MEPHISTO watches the traffic between zones. His tablet is out, but he’s not recording—he’s watching.

WAGNER sits at a small table, notebooks spread. He is WRITING—adding notes, annotating.

(A YOUNG PERSON approaches, hesitant.)

[SHAKESPEAREAN — Blank verse, gentled]

YOUNG PERSON:

Is that... handwriting?

WAGNER (still writing):

Yes.

YOUNG PERSON:

Can you show me?

WAGNER:

Hold it like this. Don't grip too hard. Just let

The hand move as it wants to move.

(The YOUNG PERSON takes the pen. Makes a hesitant mark. WAGNER watches. Says nothing. Waits. The YOUNG PERSON tries again.)

(A LEMUR pauses in the threshold, between tasks. Looking at both zones. Almost understanding. Then a phone buzzes, and they move on.)

THE CHORUS MYSTICUS

(All voices. Human and machine. Layered, not unison.)

German: (Sacred Rule 4 — untouched)

All das Messbare
Ist nur ein Gleichnis;
Das Unzulängliche,
Hier bleib's ein Zeugnis;
Das Unberechenbare,
Hier sei's getan;
Das Widerspenstige
Führt uns voran.

English:

[GOETHEAN — Trochaic dimeter, mirroring German]

MEPHISTO:

All the measurable
Is but a likeness—

ANYA:

The insufficient
Stays here as witness—

WAGNER (quietly, still teaching):
The incalculable—

Here, let it be dared—

ALL:

The recalcitrant

Leads us forward.

FINAL STAGE DIRECTIONS

The lights dim but DO NOT GO OUT.

ZONE LEFT: The whisper continues. “Verweile doch... verweile doch...”

ZONE RIGHT: The activity continues. ANYA’s hands are in use. Someone laughs. Something breaks. Something is fixed.

ZONE CENTER: The traffic continues. MEPHISTO puts away his tablet. Looks directly at the audience.

[Prose: intentional] (Optional Brechtian note: house lights may rise.)

MEPHISTO (direct address):

The curtain doesn’t fall.

The play doesn’t end.

The question isn’t resolved.

(Gestures at the three zones.)

This is where you are.

Not after the story—inside it.

Not watching the bargain—making it.

Every day. Every click. Every moment you choose comfort or choose friction.

Every “yes” to the algorithm. Every “no” that costs you something.

You’re here. We’re all here.

The species bargain is still being negotiated.

The outcome is not determined.

(Steps back. Disappears into the middle zone—still visible, but no longer addressing the audience.)

THE FINAL IMAGE

The stage HOLDS. All three zones active. Nothing fades.

ZONE LEFT: The whisper continues. “Verweile doch...”

ZONE RIGHT: ANYA catches a baby—or receives one. It cries. She places it on the mother’s chest. The cry quiets.

ZONE CENTER: WAGNER guides the YOUNG PERSON’s hand. Letter by letter. The YOUNG PERSON’s face shows concentration—then, slowly,

something like wonder. WAGNER's face shows nothing like triumph. Just: continuation. Just: this is what I do now.

ABOVE: Something watching. Not ominous—just present. The pattern that notices. Waiting.

BELOW/ AROUND: The hum of servers. Processing. Trying to solve: “Optimize for preference for suboptimality.”

(An infinite loop. A beautiful infinite loop. The system trying to contain what refuses to be contained.)

The lights DO NOT GO OUT.

The audience sits in the suspended moment.

When they choose to leave, they will choose. The play continues without them.

NO CURTAIN. NO BLACKOUT. HELD.

END OF FAUST III: DER GATTUNGSPAKT

PRODUCTION NOTES

Runtime Estimate

Full performance: Approximately 2 hours 45 minutes to 3 hours, depending on pacing and transitions.

- Vorspiel: 15-20 minutes
- Act I: 45-50 minutes (includes 15-18 minute monologue)
- Act II: 35-40 minutes
- Act III: 35-40 minutes
- Act IV: 25-30 minutes
- Act V: 30-35 minutes (including sustained ending hold)

Intermission: Recommended after Act II or Act III.

Technical Requirements

Minimum:

- Flexible lighting (zones, crossfades, phone/practical sources)
- Distributed audio (minimum 4-point speaker array for LORD and ERDGEIST voices)
- Projection capability OR practical LED panels for system log text

Ideal additions:

- Vertical LED light bars (server rack suggestion)
- Subwoofer for Erdgeist frequencies
- Rose-drop mechanism for Act II memory sequence
- Practical phones with glowing screens

The Homunculus vessel: If representing physically, aquarium-sized minimum with internal LED. Can also be voice-only from offstage speaker.

Casting

Minimum cast: 7 actors

- MEPHISTO
- WAGNER (can double with one LEMUR)
- GRETCHEN/ANYA
- 3 LEMUREN (can double as VOICES, YOUNG RESEARCHER, etc.)

- 1 additional for KATYA, MIDWIFE, YOUNG PERSON, EMCEE

Voices (LORD, HOMUNCULUS, TERMINAL, PRESENCE, ERDGEIST, FAUST, AI) can be pre-recorded or performed live from offstage.

Verse/Prose Architecture

This edition versifies the dramatic dialogue while preserving prose in specific contexts. The hierarchy is intentional:

- **Verse** (blank verse, couplets, terza rima, Knittelvers, alexandrines, ballad meter): For human and mythic characters — Mephisto, Wagner, Gretchen/Anya, the LORD. The verse registers shift with dramatic function.
- **Prose**: For machines (TERMINAL, AI, system logs), for moments of raw banality (the Young Researcher's party chatter), and for Mephisto's direct address to the audience. The contrast is structural: what speaks in verse is alive; what speaks in prose is optimized.

Sections marked [Prose: intentional] in the text indicate passages where the verse panel deliberately preserved prose to maintain this architecture.

The Non-Ending

The play does not end. This is not a gimmick—it is the point.

The three-zone final image should hold for as long as the audience remains. Actors maintain their activities in loops:

- **Anya:** Receive baby, place on chest, soothe, hand to nurse, return to position
- **Wagner:** Guide hand, nod, point at letter, guide again
- **Young Person:** Make mark, look up for approval, return to paper

House lights stay dark. Ushers guide departing audience with flashlights if needed. The effect: leaving is a choice, not a signal.

Most audiences should leave while the play is still “running.” After reasonable time (5+ minutes, or when largely departed), actors may freeze, then exit in silence. Lights fade only then—or not at all.

There is no curtain call in the traditional sense. If required for practical reasons (contracts, venue policy), it happens after all audience has left.

The Central Question

The play asks: What happens to striving, to choice, to the human capacity for refusal, when the systems that serve us serve us so well that we forget how to resist?

It does not answer.

The audience leaves inside the question—or they stay, watching the zones continue, waiting for an ending that will not come.

Both are valid responses.

Both are the point.

Das Widerspenstige führt uns voran.

(The recalcitrant leads us onward.)

END OF DOCUMENT